



Guide 5: The Sync Mechanics

Reward Timing, Cues & Household Consistency

CANONICAL OWNER HANDBOOK

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GUIDE 5 OF 7

Guide 5 — The Sync Mechanics

Reward Timing, Cues & Household Consistency

Dogs learn through precise temporal association. This guide tightens marker timing, eliminates accidental rewards for bad behavior, and aligns the whole family on one clear cue set.



Section 5.1 • The 1-Second Pay Window & Precision Markers

Focus: Marker Training | **Time:** 4 min read

The Situation:

The dog sits, the owner says 'good boy,' fumbles in their pocket for 8 seconds, and delivers a treat after the dog has already stood up.

The Science & Mechanics:

Associative learning requires reinforcer delivery within a 0.5-1.5 second window. Late rewards reinforce the movement occurring at delivery.

Action Protocol:

- Charge the Marker: Select a crisp, short syllable ("Yes!") or clicker. Pair: Click -> Treat immediately 20 times.
- The 3-Step Sequence: Behavior Occurs -> Marker Fired -> Treat Delivered to mouth within 2 seconds.
- Treat Accessibility: Wear a treat pouch or keep pea-sized rewards ready in hand, not buried in pockets.

■■ CAUTION

Common Trap: Using the marker word as an attention-getter ("Yes! Yes! Look here!"). Markers are camera shutters capturing completed behaviors.

■■ DECISION RULE

Immutable Rule: The marker captures the exact millisecond; the hand delivers the reward.

■ CLINICAL ESCALATION

When to Get Professional Help: If a dog shows zero food motivation in a calm home, assess diet, health, or overfeeding before training.

Section 5.2 • Extinguishing Accidental Payoffs

Focus: Extinction & Habits | **Time:** 5 min read

The Situation:

The dog jumps on guests, steals kitchen towels, or barks at the dinner table, and family members alternate between scolding and laughing.

The Science & Mechanics:

Intermittent variable reinforcement schedules create the most durable, hard-to-extinguish habits in behavioral psychology.

Action Protocol:

- Audit Accidental Payoffs: Jumping (guests pet dog) -> Counter-surfing (roast beef left on edge) -> Stealing items (chase game).
- Management Fixes: Clean benches completely. Put dog on leash with guest arrival so jumping is physically prevented.
- Extinction Burst Awareness: When reinforcement stops, the behavior temporarily spikes in intensity before dying out. Stay consistent.

■■ CAUTION

Common Trap: Giving in 'just this once' after 10 minutes of barking. This directly trains the dog to bark longer next time.

■■ DECISION RULE

Immutable Rule: Control the environment so unwanted behaviors never receive an accidental payoff.

■ CLINICAL ESCALATION

When to Get Professional Help: If resource guarding accompanies stolen items (growling over socks), do not chase; begin professional trade protocols.

Section 5.3 • The Household Cue Constitution

Focus: Household Consistency | **Time:** 4 min read

The Situation:

Mom says 'Down' (lie on floor), Dad says 'Down' (get off couch), and the kids yell 'Off', leaving the dog completely bewildered.

The Science & Mechanics:

Canines discriminate specific auditory phonemes paired with body postures, not general semantic concepts.

Action Protocol:

- Define the Vocabulary: 'Sit' (bottom down), 'Drop' (chest on floor), 'Off' (paws off furniture/humans), 'Wait' (pause at thresholds).
- Release Cue: Establish an explicit release word ('Free' or 'Break') so the dog knows when a position ends.
- The Single Cue Rule: Say the verbal cue once. If ignored, do not repeat it 5 times. Guide with a physical hand lure.

■■ CAUTION

Common Trap: Chanting verbal commands like background noise until the dog learns to filter them out.

■■ DECISION RULE

Immutable Rule: One cue, one word, one criteria, agreed upon by every member of the household.

■ CLINICAL ESCALATION

When to Get Professional Help: If multiple family members have conflicting training philosophies causing behavioral regression, book a family trainer consultation.